BIOLOGICAL/PHYSICAL FALSE BELIEF #8 · CHRONIC PAIN

"I can't be happy as long as I hurt."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Pain narrows attention, and joy can seem like something that belongs to healthy people. We may stop doing what we enjoy and give up on laughter, connection, and meaning until the pain is gone.

What Scripture teaches

Paul wrote, "I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances," and described himself as "Sorrowful, yet always rejoicing" (2 Corinthians 6:10). The psalmist says, "When anxiety overwhelms me, Your consolation delights my soul" (Psalm 94:19). Joy is not the absence of pain. It is a gift that can exist beside pain, in small and real moments, and in the nearness of God.

> *"When anxiety overwhelms me, Your consolation delights my soul"* (Psalm 94:19).

Also see

> "I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength" (Philippians 4:12–13).

> "Sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; poor, yet making many rich; having nothing, and yet possessing everything" (2 Corinthians 6:10).

> "Then Nehemiah told them, 'Go and eat what is rich, drink what is sweet, and send out portions to those who have nothing prepared, since today is holy to our Lord. Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.'" (Nehemiah 8:10).

> "You have made known to me the path of life; You will fill me with joy in Your presence, with eternal pleasures at Your right hand" (Psalm 16:11).

Common self-statements

- Happiness is impossible while I hurt.
- I do not deserve to enjoy anything.
- Joy would be fake.
- Hurting people cannot laugh.
- I will be happy when the pain stops.
- Nothing feels good.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either pain-free and happy or miserable.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I cannot enjoy anything.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling pain and concluding joy is impossible.
- Labeling: Calling myself unable to enjoy life.

Challenging questions

- When have I felt a moment of peace or joy despite pain?

- What small pleasures are still possible?
- What did Paul and the psalmists experience in suffering?
- Whom do I enjoy being with?
- What would I tell a friend who felt this way?
- What gentle joy can I plan this week?

Truth summary

> Joy and pain can exist together. I can look for small gifts each day, receive God's consolation, and enjoy what I can, without waiting for the pain to end.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Joy
- Suffering
- Thankful
- Sickness
- Hardship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Weak/Tired

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't be happy as long as I hurt"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't be happy as long as I hurt." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When have I felt a moment of peace or joy despite pain?
- ☐ What small pleasures are still possible?
- ☐ What did Paul and the psalmists experience in suffering?
- ☐ Whom do I enjoy being with?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend who felt this way?
- ☐ What gentle joy can I plan this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's consolations delight my soul.
- ☐ I can be sorrowful yet rejoicing.
- ☐ Contentment can be learned.
- ☐ Joy is found in His presence.
- ☐ Small joys count.
- ☐ I can enjoy what I can.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 94:19
  "When anxiety overwhelms me, Your consolation delights my soul."
- ☐ Philippians 4:12–13
  "I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 6:10
  "Sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; poor, yet making many rich; having nothing, and yet possessing everything."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Small joys: Each day, name one moment of joy or peace.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 94:19 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God's consolations delight my soul even in pain.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Joy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] List possible joys. Write simple things you can still enjoy.
- [ ] Plan one this week. Schedule a gentle activity.
- [ ] Share it. Tell someone about the moment.
- [ ] Thank God. Name one gift each night.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't be happy as long as I hurt": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Small joys
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't be happy as long as I hurt.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, pain has taken my joy. Give me Your consolation, help me notice small gifts, and let me enjoy what I can. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.